Dog Sees God

By Bert V. Royal

CB, a handsome, however sullen, teenager. (Voice over by Actor 2 as he "writes")

CB: **(Pg 7-8)** Dear Pen Pal. I know it's been a few years since I last wrote you. I hope you're still there. I'm not sure you ever were. I never got any letters back from you when I was a kid. It was pretty frustrating when I was young, but now I'm glad that you won't respond. Just listen. That's what I want. *(beat)* My dog died. I don't know if you remember, but I had a beagle. I went out to feed him and he didn't come bounding out like usual. I looked in the doghouse. There was blood everywhere. The blood belonged to a little yellow bird that had always been around. My dog and the bird used to play together. . . Anyway, the bird had been mangled. Ripped apart. By my dog. My parents called a center and they came and took him away. Later that day, they put him to sleep. When my dog died, that was when the rain cloud came back and everything went to hell . . .

INTRODUCTION

Even the most devoted fans of the comic strip "Peanuts" must wish that Charlie Brown would just once change out of that yellow, jagged-striped shirt. Or shave his string of hair, kick that darn football or do something -- anything -- different. In this selection, that wish comes true for not only Charlie Brown, but for others in the original comic strip as well. They grow up and their transformation is definitely . . . different. Pigpen has grown up into a violent, homophobic jock – You'll see him here as Matt. Charlie Brown, or CB, as he's called, becomes a popular kid with a mean streak who is still questioning his place in the world. And Beethoven (think Schroeder), the artistic pianist, has been long abused by the popular kids and his father.

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CB: **(Pg 20-24)** *(to audience)* I was passing by the music room when I heard a song. The song was simple. Much more simple than what he usually played. *(beat)*

Lights up on Beethoven playing the piano. He has a black eye. CB enters unseen by Beethoven. He stands and listens to the music, as if hypnotized by it. He begins to cry silently, but then accidentally lets out a sob. Beethoven abruptly stops, spins around and sees him. CB pulls himself together.

BEETHOVEN: You're not supposed to be in here. I have permission to practice during lunch. But nobody else.

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CB: You've gotten really good. I mean, you always were, but - Who wrote that? Beethoven?

BEETHOVEN: Chopin.

CB: Do you mind if I just listen for a little while? *(Beethoven resumes; CB cries)* God. This is really embarrassing. *(pause)* My dog died. He got rabies. They, um, had to put him under. *(beginning to ramble) H*ave you ever had someone close to you die and you can't stop thinking about what's happened to them? It's like you're stuck in this morbid place and there's so much death that you feel like your head is going to explode and it makes you think that maybe you're dead, too. *(Beethoven slams his fist down on the keys)* What?

BEETHOVEN: Well, it's just that you haven't spoken to me in years. Except to call me a "faggot" or to dislocate my shoulder and all of a sudden I get a stream-of-consciousness monologue about your dead dog while I'm trying to spend the only moments of my day that don't truly SUCK. Forgive my bluntness. But I *don't care* about you or your morbid curiosities or your dead dog, so why don't you just leave?

CB: We were just messing with you.

BEETHOVEN: I haven't had lunch in the cafeteria in two and a half years for fear of going home with some part of it smeared across my shirt! I haven't been in a bathroom on campus since the time my head got slammed into the wall. I believe you were there. And what really kills me is that everybody wonders why kids bring guns to school. Maybe you're not the bully, but you stand idly by and watch. In my eyes that makes you even worse. So - Please. Just. Go.

CB: Maybe if you didn't act so – Well. Gay.

BEETHOVEN: And how does one act gay? *(silence)* By playing the piano? Maybe I'll stop carrying around a pink purse. What?! What is it?!

CB: You're being hostile and I'm just trying to talk to you like a civilized -

BEETHOVEN: I don't want to talk to you!!! I just want to be left alone!

CB: See, this is why you don't have any friends. Don't be so melodramatic!

BEETHOVEN: You're crying about a dead dog and I'M being melodramatic?! *(Beethoven shoves CB. CB doesn't fight back. Beethoven hits him and CB begins to laugh)* What's so funny?

CB: I'm sorry. It's just that I was scared of you for, like, a second. *(Beethoven joins in the laughter)*

BEETHOVEN: I'm sorry.

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CB: No, it's okay. I deserved it. *(beat)* Promise me you won't bring a gun to school.

BEETHOVEN: I don't know where to get one. *(silence)* You were one of my best friends. You all were. I just don't get it.

CB: It's no consolation, but - well, can I be honest? *(beat)* No one knew what to say to you after your dad got arrested . . . I'm sorry we weren't there for you. *(extends his hand)* Truce?

BEETHOVEN: Okay. Truce. *(shakes CB's hand for longer than expected. CB pulls his away)*

CB: Are you. . . ?

BEETHOVEN: I don't know. I've never had sex, so it would be hard to say at this point.

CB: But what about. . .?

BEETHOVEN: My dad? I don't think that's considered sex. *(silence)*

CB: Do you remember how my dog used to howl whenever you played the piano? What do you think happens to pets when they die?

BEETHOVEN: They go to heaven. . . There has to be some reward for having to live through this.

CB: *(looks depressed)* But my dog killed a living thing. Wouldn't God be mad?

BEETHOVEN: He was sick, CB. He couldn't help it. They say a dog sees God in his master. A cat looks in the mirror.

CB: *(chuckling)* I hate cats.

TRANSITION

When asked to describe the melancholy of his original comic strip Peanuts, Charles Shultz said . . . it's simple: "All the loves in the strip are unrequited; all the baseball games are lost; all the test scores are D-minuses; the Great Pumpkin never comes; and the football is always pulled away." Life is hard in elementary school, and it doesn't get any easier in high school. CB and Beethoven, both confused and looking for love, begin a relationship, but over the course of the next few weeks, the anxiety for Beethoven becomes more and more pronounced.

Beethoven at the piano. CB approaches with a paper sack and starts unpacking lunch on the piano.

CB: **(Pg 41-43)** I brought you lunch. *(Beethoven stops playing and gives CB a look of despair and frustration)* Hey, halfway through the day and I only got called a queer three times.

BEETHOVEN: That's because people are scared you'll beat them up.

CB: Don't worry. I've already started spreading the word that if they mess with my boyfriend, I'll

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be kicking some ass. *(kisses the top of Beethoven's head)*

BEETHOVEN: Your boyfriend? I don't want a boyfriend. . . This can't happen. CB, I really need to practice.

CB: You really need to eat.

BEETHOVEN: *(losing it)* CB! Just stop! Okay? This isn't what I want.

CB: What's the problem?

BEETHOVEN: THIS is the problem! I'm stressed out right now and I'm trying to calm my nerves by playing the piano . . . Look. The other night was great, but . . .You go back to being yourself. This is just too weird.

CB: *(getting perturbed)* Fine. I'll leave you alone. *(grabs backpack and starts to exit; turns back)*

BEETHOVEN: Just give me time. *(CB exits) (to himself)* Oh my God. *(resumes playing with a smile as Matt enters)*

MATT: Hey there, Liberace. *(Beethoven stops playing and turns, trying to conceal his terror)*

BEETHOVEN: Matt, you're not supposed to be in here.

MATT: Where's your boyfriend?

BEETHOVEN: He's not my boyfriend . . . Just leave me alone, okay? Please. I didn't do anything.

MATT: Play something. *(Beethoven doesn't move. Matt bends Beethoven's finger backwards, leading him to the keys; he begins to play)* So, are you two, like, a couple now? Are you going to parade around the halls holding hands? Go to prom together? *(beat)* Can't you people just keep it hidden? Instead of throwing it in our faces? *(Beethoven stops and looks at him; he realizes Matt's secret)* CB is not like you. And if you so much as look at him again, I'll kill you. You got that, perv? *(starts to exit)*

BEETHOVEN: No.

MATT: What? *(goes back to the piano)* What did you say?

BEETHOVEN: I said no . . . Pigpen. *(Matt grabs Beethoven in an act of violence; Beethoven screams)*

***** SCENE *******

CB: *(to audience)* Frederic Chopin died of tuberculosis on October 17, 1849. He had two requests. He was terrified of being buried alive, so he asked that his heart be removed from his body. The second request was that Mozart's "Requiem" be sung at his funeral. *(long beat)* Beethoven

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didn't leave a note. So, I don't know if he had any last requests. *(bell rings for class)*

******* Classroom. CB does not want to be there *********

TEACHER: (Pg 44-45) *(whaa – whaa question)*

CB: Huh? *(whaa – whaa question again)* How does his death make me feel? No one even liked him. Who cares? He's dead! That's life. The world is full of people who have tough lives. But do you see them killing themselves? No. There are people out there who can't walk. Can't see. Do they give up? No. They keep going. Suicide is pathetic bullshit. It's weak. *(Losing it)* DID HE SAY GOODBYE TO ME?! I wish he was still here so I could twist his arm behind his back and shove his face in a toilet. *(hits the wall and storms off)*

******* SCENE *********

CB: (Pg 46) *(writing to his pen pal – Actor 2 voices lines while Actor 1 "acts")* Sorry for unloading all of this. *(Forcing a smile)* I bet this is the longest letter you've ever gotten. Thanks for listening. Sincerely. No. Yours truly. No. Your pen pal. CB.

TRANSITION

And weeks later, shockingly, CB's silent pen pal replies

CB stands alone, holding the letter; just staring at it. He opens it tentatively (NOTE: In the original script, which includes many more characters . . . multiple characters not included in this cutting are assigned voice-over lines from the letter while CB silently reads it – This cutting contains all the original lines which CB can present himself)

CB: Dear CB. How unexpected to get a letter from you after all these years. I thought you had forgotten about me. It sounds like you're going through a pretty rough time and having to deal with situations that you feel like you can't handle - But if anyone is equipped to deal with these things, it's you. I promise that things get better.

I was talking to a girl the other day who told me of an incident that happened at her high school. There was a boy. Bullied. Tormented. To the point of opening fire on their cafeteria. He was quiet and awkward. No one ever spoke to him unless it was to insult him. He took the lives of many people. How differently things could have been through just one connection. No matter how great or small.

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She lives where I live now. A place where there is no violence. Everyone treats others with kindness, love and respect. Can you imagine such a place? Don't concern yourself with death. Immerse yourself in life. Enjoy every moment that you're allowed. But keep asking questions, my dear friend.

A boy recently came to live down the street from me. He's had a tough life, but things are better for him now. He plays the piano like your friend. I often hear his music wafting from an open window, where a small yellow bird sits. Sometimes I cry when I hear it. But mostly I smile. He found a dog who likes to sing along. He tells me of a person he knew; Someone very special who means more than anything to him. A person that reminds me of you.

Maintain in your heart all that makes you who you are. You are a good man. *(pause)*
Your Pen Pal. CS. *(drops the letter and cries for his dog, his friend and for himself)*

CLOSING

C.S. -- Could this be Charles Shultz? or a symbolic message from the "Creator" or God. Pop culture hits like the Peanuts endure by being constantly recreated and experimented on by fervent fans. RIP Charles Shultz, your characters and your legacy live on.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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